

Complete transformers

Instead of changing slowly, insects in this group undergo an abrupt change in shape, or complete metamorphosis. Their young, or larvae, usually look nothing like their parents, with no sign of wings and sometimes no legs. Many are called grubs or maggots. The larvae usually live in a different habitat from their parents and eat a different kind of food. When a larva is mature, it enters a resting stage called a pupa or chrysalis. Its body is dismantled, and an adult's body built in its place.



Goliath beetles are Earth's heaviest insects, weighing up to 3 ½ oz (100 g).



Ladybugs are brightly colored beetles that feed on aphids and other sap-sucking insects.



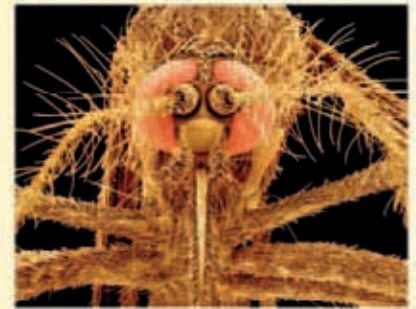
There are nearly 50,000 types of weevil, each with dainty jaws at the end of a long snout.



Often bright or metallic, leaf beetles eat plants, including crops such as potatoes.



Fierce diving beetles swim in freshwater using their hind legs. The larvae are called water tigers.



Mosquitoes suck blood with their syringelike mouths. Like all flies, they have only two wings.



Houseflies liquefy their food by spitting onto it. They then suck it up with spongelike mouthparts.



Horseflies drink with their lapping mouthparts. They are blood-feeders that slice into their prey.



Fleas suck blood while living aboard mammals and birds. They are wingless, but good jumpers.



All wasps have stings, but some live in delicate group nests, which they build from chewed wood.



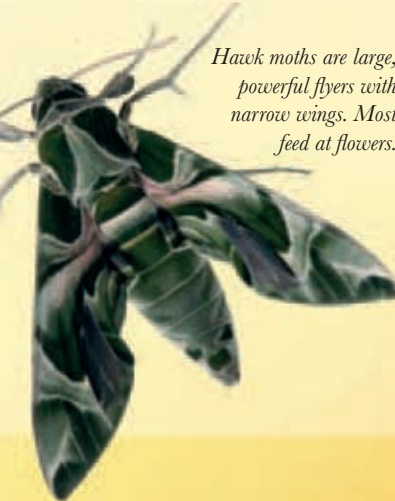
Bumblebees are large bees with furlike scales. They feed on pollen and nectar from flowers.



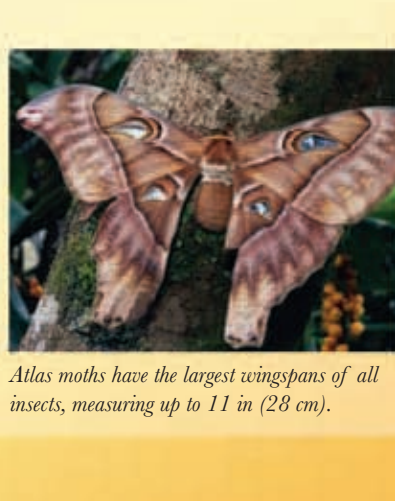
Some members of honey ant nests have swollen abdomens that store liquid food.



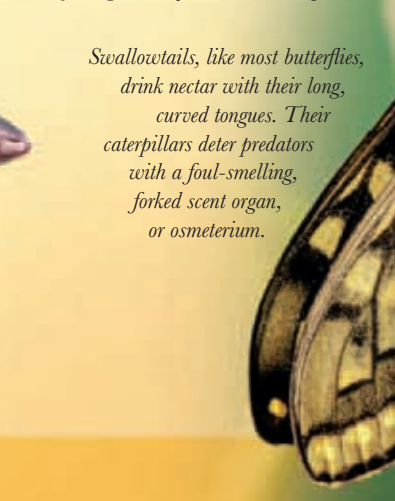
Morpho butterflies have large, iridescent wings. Their forelegs are tiny and brush-shaped.



Hawk moths are large, powerful flyers with narrow wings. Most feed at flowers.



Atlas moths have the largest wingspans of all insects, measuring up to 11 in (28 cm).



Swallowtails, like most butterflies, drink nectar with their long, curved tongues. Their caterpillars deter predators with a foul-smelling, forked scent organ, or osmeterium.

